though unsuccessfully, to prevent the elected assembly members from entering the building where they were going to meet. On 4 September, the Indian parliament, the Lok Sabha, voted in favour of making Sikkim an ‘associate state’.

Beijing perceived this as an Indian takeover of Sikkim and China’s foreign minister, Qiao Guanhua, lashed out against India in a speech before the UN General Assembly on 2 October 1974. He also seized the opportunity to condemn the Soviet Union: ‘The Indian Government’s annexation of Sikkim has aroused the opposition of the Sikkimese people as well as the Indian people and met with condemnation by India’s neighbours and world public opinion. The Soviet propaganda organs alone sing praises of India. This shows that the Soviet revisionist social-imperialism is the boss behind the scenes of Indian expansionism.’[39]

With the kazi as Sikkim’s first democratically elected chief minister and the kazini by his side, events unfolded briskly. On 10 April 1975, the Sikkim Assembly decided to abolish the institution of the chogyal. Thondup was confined to his palace where he remained under virtual house arrest. Four days later, a referendum was held and an overwhelming majority voted for a final merger agreement with India. On 23 April, the Lok Sabha voted to make Sikkim the 22nd state of the Indian Union, a decision that went into effect on 16 May.

Predictably, the Chinese condemned the moves. On 29 April, the Chinese government issued a statement saying that it ‘solemnly states once again that it absolutely does not recognize India’s annexation of Sikkim and firmly supports the people of Sikkim in their just struggle for national independence and in defence of state sovereignty against Indian expansionism’.[40]

But there were few signs of any such ‘struggle’ by ‘the people of Sikkim’. The relatively smooth merger of Sikkim with the rest of India occurred during the rise of the country’s new external intelligence agency, the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW). As opposition to the rule of the chogyal was mounting, it sent agents to Gangtok, Mangan, Namchi, and Gyalshing, the headquarters of the then four districts of Sikkim, where they collected information and, India began supporting the opposition from behind the scene.[41] According to researcher Asoka Raina, RAW operatives established a close relationship with people who were opposed to the